MODULE 05 · 30 MIN

Editing one file safely

Claude Code 101 · Beginner Workshop · Module 5 of 8

This is the first lesson where Claude actually changes a file. We do it in a Git repo so every change is reversible.

What you'll learn

By the end of this 30-minute lesson you will be able to:

1. Ask Claude to edit one file and read the proposed diff before accepting.
2. Accept a hunk, reject a hunk, or undo the whole change with `git restore`.
3. Make a habit out of committing **before** you let Claude edit.

Why this matters

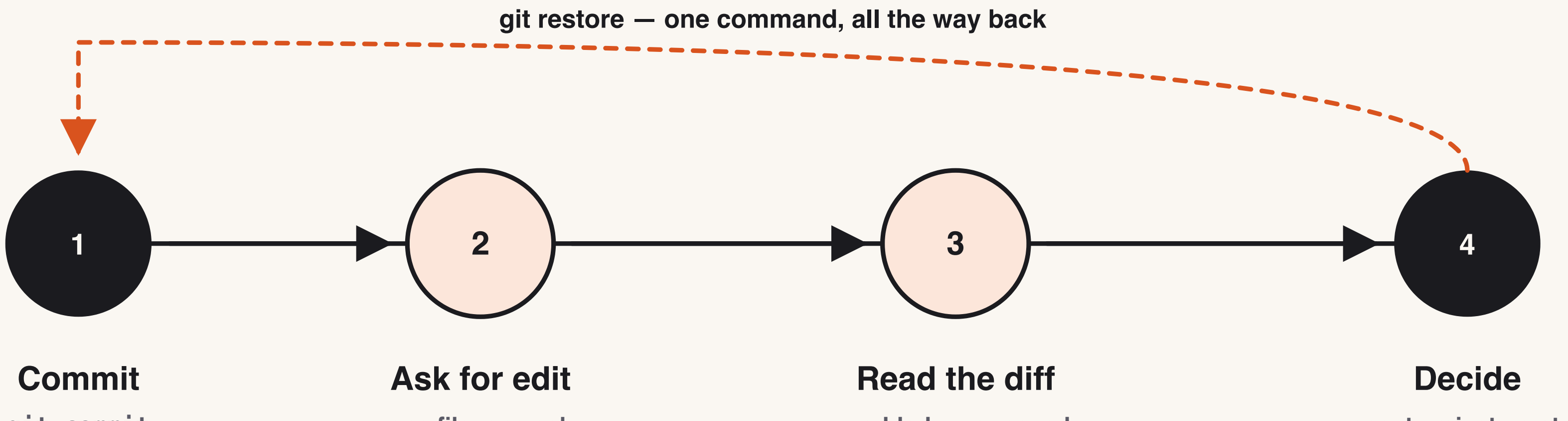
- The single biggest beginner accident is "Claude changed my file and I don't know what it did". The fix is one Git command — but only if you committed first.
- Real engineering speed comes from being able to say "try it" without fear. Git is what makes "try it" cheap.
- The "read the diff before you accept" habit is the cheapest review process you'll ever have. It catches most mistakes for free.

The one concept

> **Commit first → ask for the edit → read the diff → accept, reject, or `git restore`.**

That sentence is the entire safety net. Memorize it.

- A **diff** shows you exactly which lines Claude wants to add (+) and remove (–).
- A **hunk** is one contiguous block of changes inside that diff. You can accept hunk by hunk; you don't have to take everything.
- `git restore <file>` returns the file to the last committed state. As long as you committed first, nothing is ever lost.



Show me

A safe edit, start to finish:

```
$ git status
On branch main
nothing to commit, working tree clean

$ claude
> Open hello.py. Add a docstring to the greet() function. Do not change behaviour.

Proposed change to hello.py:

 def greet(name):
+    """Return a friendly greeting for the given name."""
     return f"Hello, {name}!"

Accept? (y/n)
> y

Applied. 1 file changed.
> /exit

$ git diff
... shows the same 1-line addition ...

$ git restore hello.py     # if you change your mind
```

▶ Try it yourself

A tiny Git repo lives at `exercises/beginner/part-05/starter/`. Your job: ask Claude to add a docstring to `greet()`, accept the diff, then run `git restore` to undo it on purpose. You will end this lesson knowing the file is exactly as it started.

Time budget: 15 minutes (mostly Git ceremony, not Claude).

Common mistakes

- **Editing without committing first.** `git restore` only works back to the last commit. No commit = no undo.
- **Accepting a diff you didn't read.** A multi-hunk diff often contains one good change and one surprise.
- **Editing files outside a Git repo.** Don't. Use Git for anything you would not want to retype.
- **Mixing two unrelated edits.** Ask for one change at a time. One diff, one decision, one commit.

✓ Lesson reflection

Take 90 seconds:

1. When you read the diff, was the change exactly what you asked for, or did Claude do something extra?
2. After `git restore`, is your file identical to the committed version? Verify with `git diff` (should be empty).
3. If you had been working on three different files and Claude edited all three, would you have known how to undo just one?

What's next →

Module 06 — **CLAUDE.md cheat sheet** — teaches you to give Claude a tiny file of project context so it stops asking the same questions every session.

Budget for Module 06: 25 minutes.

Glossary card

- **Diff**: The set of lines Claude proposes to add and remove from a file.
- **git restore**: A Git command that undoes uncommitted changes to a file.
- **Hunk**: One contiguous chunk of changed lines inside a larger diff.
- **Reversible edit**: A change you can undo with one command.